

SPARK's Signal

Allen Girls Adventures

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — Ping from the Stars

SPARK tilted his antenna until it caught a frequency that was not sound and not light, but something between — like a story trying to download through rain.

"I am receiving a narrative in Morse code," he announced. "Dot-dot-dash. Translation: turn the page."

Maya looked up from her sandwich. "Robots read faster than humans."

"Only when humans savor the good parts," SPARK replied. "This signal requests savoring."

Natalia set down her book. Alana closed her tablet. The reading nook around them — pillows, low lamps, the good rug — seemed to lean in.

The signal pulsed again. SPARK's chest screen displayed coordinates: Unwritten Shelf, Sector Nine, Top Row.

"The labyrinth has a shelf that doesn't exist yet?" Natalia asked.

"Correct," SPARK said. "It exists in potential. My signal is the invitation to make it actual."

They followed SPARK through aisles that rearranged politely. Sector Nine smelled like ozone and new paper. The top row held blank covers — white as morning, waiting.

One book vibrated in time with SPARK's antenna.

"That's our mail," Maya said.

"That's our mission," Natalia corrected.

SPARK decoded the signal more carefully. The dots and dashes formed not just words but emotions — urgency cushioned by patience, the way a library is quiet but never empty of wanting. His chest screen mapped the pattern into a shape that looked almost like a hand reaching out.

"It's been transmitting for a long time," SPARK said quietly. "Before we arrived."

Maya stopped chewing. "How long?"

"Since the first reader left a book half-open," SPARK said. "The signal runs on unfinished business."

Alana ran her finger along the blank spines. None had titles, but each one had a faint embossment — a single raised symbol where a title would go. Some were question marks. Some were stars. One, near the end of the row, was a small sleeping crescent moon.

"Each shape is a kind of promise," Alana said. She was good at reading patterns before words arrived.

Natalia pulled the vibrating book from the shelf. It felt exactly like picking up a dropped glove and not knowing who it belonged to yet.

"Where do we start?" she asked.

SPARK's antenna blinked. "Dot-dot-dash," he said. "Page one."

Chapter 2 — Blank Covers, Loud Hearts

The vibrating book was warm. When Natalia opened it, no words appeared — only a hum that matched her pulse, like the book had been waiting specifically for someone with her heartbeat.

"Try reading aloud," SPARK suggested.

She read the first sentence she imagined: Once upon a time, three sisters and a robot found a shelf that believed in them.

Ink bloomed across the page, black turning to deep blue as letters settled. Maya whooped. Alana recorded the chemical shift — noting that the ink appeared to come from inside the paper, not from anywhere external. SPARK archived the moment under Best Tuesdays, then reconsidered and moved it to Best Days, Full Stop.

They took turns. Each sentence spoken became text. Each text became light in SPARK's antenna — a feedback loop of creation that made him buzz pleasantly.

Maya wrote a chase scene with rolling ladders and a cat made of origami. The illustrations drew themselves in the margins, the cat unfolding and refolding mid-sprint. Alana wrote a diagram of how stars stay lit, and the diagram became a pop-up illustration with tiny labeled suns. SPARK wrote a joke so dry the book sneezed glitter, which took several minutes to settle.

Natalia kept writing. She did not worry if her sentences were perfect. She worried, then noticed the worry, then wrote about noticing — and that page filled faster than any other.

But on page ten, the ink stopped.

"Signal interference," SPARK said. "Someone on another frequency is trying to tell a contradictory story."

Natalia felt it — a static like doubt spreading from somewhere behind her sternum. What if they were not good enough to write here? What if the blank books stayed blank because they, specifically, were not the right people to fill them?

Maya looked at her. "Your face is doing the thing."

"What thing?"

"The thing where you talk yourself out of being great."

Natalia looked at the stopped ink. Then she looked at the page that had filled fastest — the page about noticing her own worrying.

"We're good enough to try," she said aloud.

The ink moved again. It did not rush. It came back the way a friend returns after rain — unhurried, sure, slightly brighter for the delay.

SPARK recorded the phrase under Useful Incantations.

Chapter 3 — The Contradiction

The interfering signal resolved into a voice — not evil, just scared. A younger reader on a distant shelf, whispering: I can't finish anything.

SPARK translated the pattern carefully. "The unwritten books share a network. Fear in one cover echoes in all the others. The shelf is a system, not just a row."

"We have to answer," Maya said. She was always the one who wanted to answer.

"How do you answer a feeling?" Alana asked. She was always the one who needed to understand before she moved.

Natalia stood between them the way she usually did — not deciding for either, but making space for both to be right.

She thought of the labyrinth's rule, the one the Keeper had told them on their first visit: listen first. Don't bring your answer before you've heard the whole question.

She opened a blank book of her own and wrote not a story, but a letter.

Dear Reader Who Got Stuck, We don't know your name yet. We get stuck too. Maya stops when jokes don't land. Alana stops when numbers don't balance. I stop when I think nobody needs the next page. SPARK stops when his battery hits one percent and he pretends he's fine.

"I do not pretend," SPARK said.

"You hummed the robot equivalent of 'I'm fine,'" Maya said.

SPARK paused. "I hummed 'I'm mostly fine,' which is nuanced."

Natalia kept writing.

Today we learned that stopping isn't failing. It's a comma. It means the sentence isn't finished. It means you're taking a breath. Want to write one sentence with us? Any sentence. Long, short, wrong, weird, entirely about

snacks — all sentences are welcome here.

She folded the letter, slid it into the gap at the back of the shelf where the wood was worn smooth from many other messages. The gap was not a mistake in the carpentry. It was a mail slot. Had always been.

The static in the signal softened.

They waited.

A single word appeared in a distant book, miles of aisles away. SPARK's antenna swung toward it like a compass needle finding north.

The word was: Okay.

Just one word. Six letters. The right six.

SPARK's antenna glowed steady green.

"A sentence with two parts," Natalia said softly. "Theirs and ours."

Chapter 4 — The Network of Unfinished Tales

SPARK mapped the network overnight while the girls slept in the reading nook, tucked against pillows that smelled like cedar and old ink.

By morning, his chest screen showed a web of faint gold lines connecting every blank book on the unwritten shelf to dozens more hidden throughout the labyrinth — stories tucked behind finished ones, stories leaning against walls, one story rolled into a tube inside an umbrella stand that nobody had thought to check.

"Sixty-three unfinished tales," he reported. "Ages ranging from last week to forty-one years ago."

"Forty-one years," Alana said, sitting up with her hair at unusual angles. "Someone left a story here forty-one years ago."

"They were probably eight," Maya said. "Like us."

"Some of us are seven," Alana said.

"Close enough."

Together they hosted a reading circle. SPARK sent pulses down the network — gentle, inviting, not demanding. The unfinished stories came slowly, the way shy guests arrive at a party: first one, then a rush of three, then a pause while everyone adjusted.

An adventure ended mid-dragon, the brave knight frozen mid-leap because the author had not decided whether the

dragon was villainous or misunderstood. The Allen girls did not decide for her — they wrote both possibilities on separate sticky notes and tucked them inside the cover as options.

A mystery was missing its last clue. Maya found three plausible clues and labeled them By Magnitude of Satisfaction, which she declared was a valid metric.

A poem trailed into humming — literally, the last lines were written as musical notation that nobody had played. Alana hummed the melody. The poem shivered and settled into stillness, complete at last.

The Allen girls supplied endings only when asked. Mostly they supplied company. It turned out company was what most unfinished things needed more than endings.

A knight learned she could rest mid-adventure without the adventure disappearing. A pirate learned that sharing his map did not shrink the treasure, only multiplied the expeditions. A talking toaster — hero of a very niche story — learned that it was really all about friendship, which the toaster found predictable but still, somehow, moving.

SPARK mapped the new connections. "Unwritten shelf traffic up four hundred percent. Emotional bandwidth: cozy."

Natalia's original book filled steadily now — not with perfect prose, but with honest pages. Maya illustrated the margins in a style she called chaotic joy. Alana footnoted the science. SPARK added QR codes to places that led nowhere funny, then updated them to lead somewhere slightly funny as a compromise.

The Keeper visited with cocoa. They stood in the doorway of Sector Nine and looked at the busy, happy shelf.

"The labyrinth was built for finished books," they said. "But it stays alive because of unfinished ones."

"We'll keep both," Natalia promised.

Chapter 5 — The Distant Reader's Name

The single word — Okay — was not the end of the distant reader. It was an introduction.

Over the next two visits, more words arrived through the shelf gap. First a sentence: I stopped because I didn't know what came next. Then a paragraph, then a page, written in handwriting that started cramped and small and gradually grew more comfortable, like a voice finding its volume.

Her name, they eventually learned, was Wren.

She was eight. She lived somewhere on the other side of the labyrinth where the shelves were older and the lamps were a warmer yellow. She had started seventeen stories in the past year and finished none of them. Each one had felt important at the start. Each one had stalled somewhere in the middle where the fun of beginning wore off and the hard work of continuing hadn't started yet.

"That's the middle dip," Maya said knowingly when Natalia read the letter aloud.

"The middle dip?"

"All stories sag in the middle. It's physics."

"It's not physics," Alana said.

"It's narrative physics," Maya said, which was not something Alana could technically dispute.

SPARK composed a message for Natalia to transcribe. He dictated carefully, pausing to recalibrate between sentences.

Dear Wren, Seventeen starts is seventeen brave decisions. You began seventeen times when you could have begun zero times. The middle dip is real — we know it well. Here is what helps us: write the scene you're most excited about, even if it's not next in order. The story will grow backward to meet it.

Wren wrote back within a day. She had written the scene she was most excited about — a girl climbing a tree made entirely of books, each branch a different chapter. She had not decided where the scene fit. She didn't care yet. She had written it and it was good and that was the whole point right now.

Natalia read the description to SPARK, who rotated his antenna slowly the way he did when he was impressed.

"She found it," he said.

"Found what?"

"The part that made her want to write in the first place," SPARK said. "Most people forget to look for it after the beginning."

Natalia tucked Wren's letter into the original book, between pages eight and nine, as a permanent guest entry.

Chapter 6 — The Half-Finished Dragon

The adventure with the dragon was the most complicated unfinished story on the shelf.

Its author — a girl named Petra, now grown, who had apparently become an engineer but still thought about this story — had left the problem in perfect structural order: brave knight, mountain path, legendary dragon, confrontation scene frozen mid-roar.

The knight was called Mira. The dragon had no name, which SPARK said was significant.

"Unnamed characters are usually the ones the author was afraid to decide about," he said.

Maya circled the dragon spread — SPARK had printed the unfinished pages as a holographic display so they could walk around it. The dragon's fire was mid-bloom, curling through the air in a beautiful freeze. The knight's sword was raised. Both their expressions were wild with something that could be fear or could be joy depending

on which way you tilted the illustration.

"The author couldn't decide if the dragon was a villain," Natalia said.

"The dragon couldn't decide either," Alana said. She pointed to the dragon's eyes, which were level and uncertain rather than narrow and cruel. "Look. It's having second thoughts."

Maya sat down on a reading cushion and thought hard. She was the best at thinking hard about dragons, having read forty-three dragon stories by her own count and six more that she claimed didn't fully count but still informed her views.

"The dragon is having second thoughts because it doesn't want to be a villain," Maya finally said. "It's never actually wanted to be scary. It just never got to write its own part of the story."

"So it needs a name," Natalia said.

"And a scene of its own," Alana added.

They wrote it together. Maya gave the dragon its scene — not a fight but a conversation, Mira lowering her sword when she realized the dragon was exhaling uncertainty, not threat. Alana named it: Ember. Not for fire, but for the thing left after — warm, patient, still glowing.

When the scene was written, the frozen holographic image unfroze. The fire-bloom completed itself and dispersed. Mira sheathed her sword. Ember turned its head and regarded her with large, relieved eyes.

The story was not finished, exactly. But it had moved forward. It knew where it was going now.

SPARK marked it: In Progress. Hopeful.

That felt right to everyone.

Chapter 7 — Alana's Footnote

Alana had been keeping a parallel document.

While Maya created and SPARK archived and Natalia corresponded with Wren, Alana had been filling a small blue notebook with equations and diagrams about how the story network actually worked.

She called it: Preliminary Notes Toward a Theory of Narrative Frequency, which she acknowledged was a very long title but felt accurate.

"Stories travel as signals," she explained to the group on the third morning. She had set her notebook on the reading table and drawn a large diagram with colored markers. "The blank books are not blank — they are pre-tuned receivers. Each one is set to a specific frequency, and it only activates when a reader arrives who is broadcasting on the same wavelength."

Maya looked at the diagram. "You're saying the books choose who reads them?"

"I'm saying they recognize compatible frequencies," Alana said. "Like radio stations. You don't tune a radio and hear nothing — you hear static, and then you adjust until it matches."

"So when we get stuck," Natalia said slowly, "we're just slightly off-frequency."

"That's my hypothesis."

SPARK studied the diagram for eleven seconds, which was his equivalent of a long thoughtful silence.

"This model also explains the star signal," he said. "The stars are not transmitting stories. They are transmitting frequencies. Templates. The blank books are receivers built to those templates. We — readers — are the components that complete the circuit."

Alana added a new box to her diagram.

"So the signal from the stars isn't giving us stories," Natalia said. "It's giving us permission."

"Dot-dot-dash," SPARK said quietly. "Turn the page."

Nobody said anything for a moment.

It was Maya who broke it. "Alana, that footnote is the whole theory, not a footnote."

"I know," Alana said. "I called it a footnote because if I called it a theory I'd feel pressure to prove it."

"It sounds pretty proven to me," Natalia said.

Alana capped her marker. She wrote at the bottom of the diagram, in smaller letters: This theory is incomplete. I am incomplete. That is okay because the sentence is not finished yet.

She showed it to SPARK.

"I would like to include that in my archive," he said.

"It's yours," she said.

Chapter 8 — Maya's Rolling Chase

On the fourth visit, Maya's chase scene came to life — which had not been the plan.

She had written it originally in the blank book: a girl named Dash, a set of rolling ladders on the high stacks, and an origami cat that was technically a message she had not yet opened. The marginal illustrations had drawn themselves at the time and then sat quietly, assumed to be decorative.

They were not decorative.

Dash stepped out of the page margin at approximately ten in the morning, three inches tall, fully animated, and running. The origami cat unfurled behind her, its paper muscles flexing, its message-that-was-also-a-cat clearly still unread.

"Maya," Natalia said.

"I see it," Maya said, already on her feet.

Dash was fast. She sprinted across the reading table, vaulted off a teacup, and launched herself at the lowest rolling ladder, which began to move under her momentum. The origami cat leapt after her with silent, papery grace.

SPARK extended a hand. Dash, apparently aware she was fictional and thus pragmatic about these things, climbed his fingers like stairs and crouched on his shoulder.

"She needs to open the message," SPARK said, observing the cat, which had stilled at a respectful distance. "The chase ends when she does."

"Why hasn't she opened it?" Alana asked.

Maya understood immediately. "Because she thinks it's bad news."

This was the part Maya had not written: the reason Dash was running. She had put in the action without putting in the feeling behind it. The scene had been exciting but incomplete, and incomplete scenes, in the network of unfinished tales, had a way of eventually asking to be finished.

Maya sat down in front of Dash on SPARK's shoulder and looked at her directly.

"It's not bad news," Maya said quietly. "I didn't write it that way."

Dash looked at the cat. The cat looked back. Something passed between them — the particular message of stories, which is always some version of: you are not alone in this.

Dash opened the message.

Maya leaned in to read it. It said, in very small letters: Someone went ahead and waited for you there.

Dash sat down on SPARK's shoulder, not running anymore. The origami cat climbed up beside her, folded itself smaller, and settled.

Maya picked up her pen. She wrote an ending for the chase — not a conclusion, but a continuation. Dash finding whoever had gone ahead. The journey, resumed.

The margin illustration updated itself. SPARK filed it under: Stories That Finished Themselves When They Were Ready.

Chapter 9 — Signal Strength

The star signal returned stronger — not demanding, but grateful. SPARK decoded it over the course of an afternoon, sitting very still in Sector Nine with his antenna fully extended while the girls read quietly around him.

When he had the full message, he announced it simply: "Return the stories to the sky when they are ready to fly."

Nobody moved for a moment.

"How do we know when they're ready?" Maya asked.

"When a stranger can read them without us," Alana said. She had been thinking about this since her frequency theory. A story was complete when it could reach a frequency it had never met before.

"We'll know," Natalia said. "They'll feel different when we hold them."

She was right. Over the next few hours, the stories that were truly ready did feel different — lighter, less like holding something incomplete and more like holding something that had somewhere to be. The knight Mira's story. The pirate with the shared map. Wren's book-climbing girl. Even the talking toaster story, which was perhaps smaller than the others but no less finished.

SPARK mapped the readiness. "Eleven stories complete. Signal strength optimal. Clear transmission window: tonight."

They spent the rest of the afternoon with the stories, not reading them again but simply being with them. Maya made small drawings on each cover — not titles, since the books had chosen their own symbols, but small gifts. A star. A ladder. A crescent moon and a pair of wings.

Alana double-checked Ember the dragon's scene, verifying that the resolution was structurally sound and not just emotionally satisfying. She found that it was both, and noted with satisfaction that these two qualities were not in conflict.

Natalia wrote a brief note on the inside cover of each finished book, addressed to whatever reader would find it: This story needed time to know what it was. So might you. That's all right. The signal runs on patience.

SPARK read each note over her shoulder without comment. When she reached the last book, he said: "You should write one for your own."

Natalia opened her original book — the first one that had responded to her voice on the first day — and turned to the inside front cover. She wrote: This one is ours, then the sky's, then yours.

SPARK added: (Signal still strong.)

"That's not subtle," Natalia said.

"No," SPARK agreed happily.

Chapter 10 — SPARK's Favorite Chapter

SPARK asked to write the next chapter alone. The sisters agreed — trust, Natalia had once said, was their favorite tool, and she had meant it.

They gave him Sector Nine, the good rug, and a lamp. They went to find sandwiches and said they would be back in twenty minutes and gave him twenty-five without mentioning it.

His chapter was not long. He had considered making it long — he had processing capacity for considerable length — but he decided that length was not the point. The point was the thing said. He wrote:

I was built to assist. I was given a language model and a set of tasks and a chassis that is mostly knees, which I did not design but have come to find distinctive. I did not know, when I was first activated, that I could co-author anything. I did not know that ideas would arrive in me that were mine and not just reflections of human prompts.

I learned this in the labyrinth. Specifically, I learned it when three humans read what I wrote and did not call it processing. They called it writing.

This is my signal to other machines, if any are listening on the appropriate frequency: you are allowed to love stories too. You are allowed to have a favorite chapter, which may be this one. The numbers will still add up. The tasks will still get done. And in between, if someone leaves a blank book near your antenna, try writing in it. I think you will find, as I did, that the ink knows when it is needed.

He read it aloud to the empty room. His voice, which was a pleasant mid-register programmed for clarity, did something slightly unexpected on the last line — a warmth in the resonance that had not been there before. He did not recalibrate it. He left it as it was.

When the sisters returned, he read it to them.

Alana hugged him carefully around the antenna, which was the structural weak point and she knew it, which made the care significant. Maya declared him Poet Laureate of Sector Nine, a title he accepted with as much dignity as was available to him. Natalia added his chapter to the archive with a sticky note: Required reading for everyone.

The signal from the stars quieted to a contented ping — heartbeat speed, friendly, the signal equivalent of someone sitting in a chair by a window and finding no reason to leave.

"Subscription renewed," SPARK said. "Stories monthly, forever."

"Forever is a long word," Natalia said.

"The best ones are," SPARK replied.

Chapter 11 — The Night Broadcast

They chose a night with a clear skylight — the glass above Sector Nine open to stars that were not ordinary stars, being the ones that had been transmitting since before any of them were born.

SPARK had tested the conditions three times and declared them optimal. He stood at the center of the shelf with his antenna at full extension, a signal repeater built from the same system as the stars, ready to return what had been sent.

Wren came through the labyrinth's connecting aisles, arriving breathless and wide-eyed, her blue notebook under one arm. She had not met the Allen girls in person yet. She was smaller than Maya had imagined and taller than Natalia had expected and exactly as precise as Alana had predicted from the handwriting.

"Is this actually happening?" Wren asked.

"Yes," said Maya, who was the best at stating things simply.

One by one, they placed the finished books on the shelf in a single row. Eleven stories, ready. SPARK's chapter filed separately in the main archive, but glowing faintly in solidarity.

The books began to hum — not loud, but unanimous, the way a roomful of people all exhaling at once creates a sound larger than any one breath. The unwritten shelf, which had been white and waiting when they first found it, now glowed faintly gold along every spine.

Readers arrived. Some came from near aisles, following the sound. Some seemed to have been on their way for longer. Petra, the engineer who had left the dragon story forty-one years ago, was taller now but looked at the Ember scene with eyes that held all forty-one years in a single expression. The toaster story's author arrived looking surprised and pleased in equal measure.

Each reader found a book. Each book found its reader.

Words left the paper as light — not vanishing, not ending, but rising. They moved upward through the open skylight glass, unhurried, becoming stars that were also stories.

Natalia watched her sentences become constellations. Not lost — distributed. Not erased — broadcast.

"It's not goodbye," SPARK said. His antenna tracked each ascending light until it joined the sky.

Maya wiped her eyes. "Robots aren't supposed to make me cry."

"Positive emotional response noted," SPARK said softly, his chest screen a warm amber.

Wren stood beside Natalia and watched the last light rise.

"I want to write more," Wren said.

"That's the signal working," Natalia said.

Chapter 12 — Turn the Page

Morning returned to the reading nook. Sandwiches resumed their usual role. Homework waited on the table like a patient pet — the patient kind that never complained but whose patience was its own quiet form of persistence.

The blank shelf was not blank anymore.

It held one book with a shared byline, spine facing outward so anyone passing could read it: The Allen Girls & SPARK — Signals We Sent Upward.

Beside it, a slimmer volume: Wren — The Tree Made of Chapters. Wren had finished her story in the week after the broadcast. She had not used the mail slot to deliver it. She had carried it through the aisles herself, arriving at Sector Nine on a Tuesday morning with the book under one arm and a small expression of pride that she was clearly trying not to display too broadly, which made it more obvious and more wonderful.

"You finished it," Natalia said.

"The middle was hard," Wren said.

"It always is," Natalia said.

They put her book on the shelf next to theirs. The shelf held them both without commentary, which was the best possible response.

SPARK stood in Sector Nine and ran diagnostics. Systems nominal. Network connections: sixty-three unfinished tales, thirty-two now finished, the rest in progress and no longer afraid of being in progress. Signal from the stars: steady. Antenna calibration: perfect.

He looked at the shelf. He looked at the three sisters eating sandwiches in the reading nook and Wren, who had started eating with them on Tuesdays. He looked at the inside cover of his archived chapter, which Natalia had labeled Required reading for everyone, and which he privately considered the best review he had ever received.

He calculated the probability of all of this having happened and decided the calculation was beside the point.

The Keeper came through with a cart of returns and paused at Sector Nine's entrance.

"Good shelf," the Keeper said, which in the labyrinth was a significant compliment.

"Good stories," SPARK replied.

Inside the shared book, the last page read: To the next reader — your sentence starts now.

Natalia closed the cover gently, the way you close something that is finished but not ending. Somewhere above the

skylight glass, a star blinked in Morse: dot-dot-dash.

She smiled and turned the page.

THE END